

admit I was curious. I was still at the beginning of my Lean Startup journey and didn't have much appreciation for the challenges faced by a Fortune 1000 company like his.

My conversations with Cook and Intuit chief executive officer (CEO) Brad Smith were my initiation into the thinking of modern general managers, who struggle with entrepreneurship every bit as much as do venture capitalists and founders in a garage. To combat these challenges, Scott and Brad are going back to Intuit's roots. They are working to build entrepreneurship and risk taking into all their divisions.

For example, consider one of Intuit's flagship products. Because TurboTax does most of its sales around tax season in the United States, it used to have an extremely conservative culture. Over the course of the year, the marketing and product teams would conceive one major initiative that would be rolled out just in time for tax season. Now they test over five hundred different changes in a two-and-a-half-month tax season. They're running up to seventy different tests per week. The team can make a change live on its website on Thursday, run it over the weekend, read the results on Monday, and come to conclusions starting Tuesday; then they rebuild new tests on Thursday and launch the next set on Thursday night.

As Scott put it, "Boy, the amount of learning they get is just immense now. And what it does is develop entrepreneurs, because when you have only one test, you don't have entrepreneurs, you have politicians, because you have to sell. Out of a hundred good ideas, you've got to sell your idea. So you build up a society of politicians and salespeople. When you have five hundred tests you're running, then everybody's ideas can run. And then you create entrepreneurs who run and learn and can retest and relearn as opposed to a society of politicians. So we're trying to drive that throughout our organization, using examples which have nothing to do with high tech, like the website example. Every business today has a website. You don't have to be high tech to use fast-cycle testing."

This kind of change is hard. After all, the company has a